▼ CHINTAMANI MAHARAJ, *56*

| BJP | *Surguja (ST), Chhattisgarh*



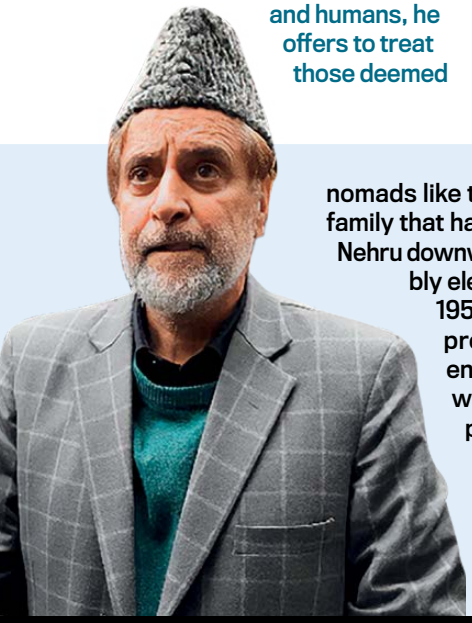
A godman can have many hands and tick many boxes. Chintamani is a dynast, having inherited godmanship from father Gahira Guru. He's a tribal priest—his shrine in north Chhattisgarh beckons both his Kanwar tribe as well as the Oraon. He is also a Sanskritist, having picked up enough proficiency while clearing his Class 12 (as late as in 2014) to even chair the state's Sanskrit board once. He's also politically ambidextrous: first a BJP MLA (2008-13), then Congress (2018-23), switching back to the right hand before the 2023 assembly polls. The BJP rewarded him with a ticket from Surguja to Lutyens' Delhi.

BHOJRAJ NAG, *52* ▶

| BJP | *Kanker, Chhattisgarh*



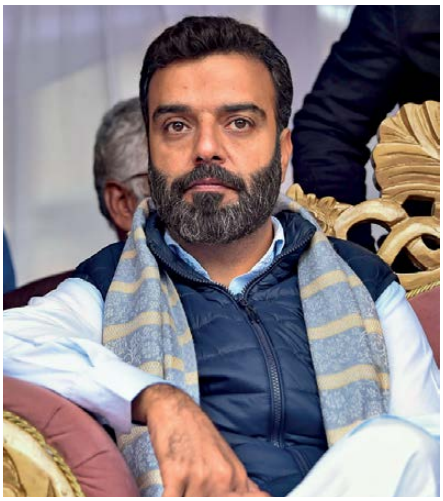
The constituents of this bone-dry end of southwest Chhattisgarh would like nothing more than potable water. The long-haired Bhojraj offers them dharma on tap. The anti-conversion, pro-Sanatana activist with a yen for controversial remarks started dispensing his wisdom at the grassroots. Claiming supernatural powers as a medium between the gods and humans, he offers to treat those deemed beyond cure by modern medicine. During the campaign, Nag offered his services for development and said if any deficit popped up on that front, he would rectify it using *jhaad phoonkh* (shamanic voodoo) and slicing a lemon. CM Vishnu Deo Sai concurred, saying Nag as MP would banish all *bhooths* (ghosts) from Kanker.



nomads like the Bakerwals. Heir to a political family that has consorted with everyone from Nehru downward and has never lost an assembly election for three generations since 1952. His grandfather was founding president of the Gujjar-Jat Conference. His father, Mian Bashir Larvi, was a Padma Bhushan, a scholar, a pacifist, a lover of fine horses and cars, and several times minister. So has Altaf been, twice, since his legislative career began in 1987.

ABID BHAT

ABID BHAT



▲ AGA SYED RUHULLAH MEHDI, *46*

| NATIONAL CONFERENCE |
Srinagar, Lok Sabha constituency

He inherited his Shia cleric status from his father Aga Syed Mehdi, an activist-politician whose assassination in 2000 was mourned even by local Kashmiri Pandits. But his religious role is not why Ruhullah's being called the "rising star of Kashmir politics". For those who haven't followed his arc as an articulate voice post-2019 and the abrogation of Article 370, his much-interrupted maiden speech in the House held a few pointers. One of the most keenly watched events in the Valley, the scripture he quoted was the rule-book, as he said to the Speaker: "You will be judged by how you handle situations when a Muslim MP is called a terrorist in the biggest institution of democracy." He lamented how the Article 370 bill "was brought in a minute, and passed in half an hour" in the previous House. Even Mehbooba Mufti, leader of Valley rival PDP, was moved to congratulate him for his "fantastic" debut. A three-time MLA, his marriage to an Iranian happened just before the election.

-Anilesh S. Mahajan, Rahul Noronha, Prashant Srivastava and Moazum Mohammad